le déluge is his motto. He wishes to get home, but is afraid of what he has already done.'[27]

Macnaghten, meanwhile, was pursuing a third approach: he was still toying with the idea of actually bolstering Shuja's power, possibly just to irritate Burnes, but like his deputy wanted to expand the regime's frontiers and to attack Herat, believing, correctly, that Yar Mohammad was encouraging the tribes to rise up against the British. He also wished to annex and 'macadamise' the Punjab, as well as to advance north beyond Bamiyan and annex the Uzbek territories of the Mir Wali, so as to fix Shuja's frontier on the banks of the Oxus, ready to face any Russian advance out of Central Asia.[28]

But against all these ambitious schemes for bringing in more soldiers and hugely extending British control, there stood the unassailable fact of a now almost completely drained treasury in Calcutta. Occupying Afghanistan is always a very expensive business, and by 1841 the combined expenses of the occupation were amounting to a colossal £2 million a year, many times what had initially been expected, and far more than the profits of the East India Company's opium and tea trade could support.

By February 1841, the head of the accounts department working on the figures in Calcutta was forced to write to Auckland and break the news that 'ere six months elapse, the treasures of India will be completely exhausted'.[29] By March, the full scale of the problem was dawning on Auckland. 'Money, money, money is our first, our second and our last want,' he wrote to Macnaghten. 'How long we can continue to feed you at your present rate of expenditure I cannot tell. To add to the weight would break us utterly.'

Once the accounts had been passed to the Commander-in-Chief, Sir John Keane, he was equally depressed. 'We are clearly in a great scrape,' he noted in his diary on 26 March 1841. 'That country drains us of a million a year or more – and we only, in truth, are certain of the allegiance of the people within range of our guns and cavalry . . . The whole thing will break down; we cannot afford the heavy yet increasing drain upon us in troops and money.' A few days later he added, 'it will never do to have India drained of a million and a quarter annually [the real figure was actually much higher] for a rocky frontier, requiring about 25,000 men and expensive establishments to hold it'.[30]